OPERATIONAL EXCELLENCE · WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Hospitals tried a “Do not interrupt” vest to protect nurses giving medications.

A randomized trial found no evidence that it reduced errors.

That is what five studies, published from 2021 to 2025, show.

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THE MEDICATION ROUND

What happens during a medication round?

Nurses are interrupted again and again: a colleague has a question, a doctor needs something, or a missing item has to be found.

In a review of 22 studies, 16 found a significant link between interruptions and more medication administration errors.

The studies defined interruptions and errors in different ways, and a link alone does not prove that interruptions cause errors.

WHERE DO INTERRUPTIONS COME FROM?

From colleagues, missing supplies, and phone calls

182

interruptions recorded in 15 medication rounds in a Saudi hospital. Nurses, doctors, and obstacles were the most frequent sources.

20+

interruptions an hour for pharmacists in some studies, mostly from phone calls and patient questions.

The problem goes beyond nursing.

Schroers 2025 · Eid 2022 · Ayanaw 2025

THE TRIAL

A “Do not interrupt” vest in four French hospitals

Nurses wore the vest during medication rounds, and a poster at the unit entrance explained it to patients and families.

Researchers randomly assigned 29 units: 14 used the vest and 15 kept their usual practice. Trained observers watched 383 medication rounds.

FINDINGS

No fewer errors, and no effect on interruptions

7.09%

of doses had an error on vest units, compared with 6.23% on the other units.

15.04%

of doses were interrupted on vest units, up from 13.4% before the trial. On the other units, the rate fell from 23.78% to 20.75%.

The researchers concluded that the vest had no impact on errors or on interruption rates.

Berdot et al., BMC Nurs, 2021

WHY DID THE VEST NOT WORK?

Nurse-to-nurse interruptions stayed common

In a review of 14 studies, nurses interrupting other nurses stayed common even with vests and campaigns, and the effect of these measures on errors remained unclear.

A vest targets only one source, and many interruptions are a symptom of a system that does not provide supplies or information on time.

The last sentence is the author's interpretation of these studies, not a measured result.

WHAT THE STUDIES SUGGEST

What can leaders do?

1

Start by measuring: who interrupts, when, and why?

2

Remove the causes at the source: put supplies in place, and send questions to a colleague who is not giving medications.

3

Measure the errors themselves, not how many people wore the vest.

> **Which error-sensitive task in your organization is interrupted most often, and where do the interruptions come from?**

SOURCES AND LIMITS

What this evidence can and cannot tell us

The French trial collected its data in 2017 and tested only the vest and poster.

The reviews drew on studies with different definitions, so results were not pooled.

The studies included one Arab hospital. Applying the idea to other sectors is an inference.

Editorial disclaimer: The views and analyses presented in this article represent the author's professional interpretation based on the cited sources and do not necessarily represent the official positions of the organizations mentioned. For the original, complete and most current information, please consult the primary sources and official documents listed in the references.

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